

What a clean has to cost so it pays you

Most cleaners divide the pay they want by the hours they work. That number leaves out unpaid hours, monthly costs and self-employment tax. Work these four steps once, then price every job from your own break-even rate.

Your four numbers

STEP	WORKED EXAMPLE	YOURS
1 Profit you need before tax. Gross up your take-home for self-employment tax (15.3% on 92.35% of profit) and your income tax estimate.	\$52,000 take-home, 12% income tax = \$70,394	
2 Revenue you need. Add a year of business costs: insurance, phone, apps, marketing, equipment, fees.	+ \$6,540 (\$545 a month) = \$76,934	
3 Hours customers pay for. Weeks x hours x the share that is paid. Driving, quoting and invoicing are not.	48 x 45 x 65% = 1,404 hours	
4 Break-even rate. Step 2 divided by step 3. Add your margin for the target rate.	\$54.80 an hour \$64.47 with 15%	

In this example, pay divided by all hours says **\$24.07** an hour. The real break-even is **\$54.80**.

Price floor for any job

(Hours on site + drive hours) x break-even rate + miles x vehicle cost + supplies. That is the price at zero profit. Add your margin and round up to the next \$5 for the quote.

Standard clean, 2 bed

2.5 hours, 15-mile round trip, \$8 supplies
Floor \$183.79

Quote \$220

\$36.21 profit inside it

Deep clean, 2 bed

5 hours, 15-mile round trip, \$15 supplies
Floor \$327.78

Quote \$390

\$62.22 profit inside it

Move-out clean, 3 bed

7 hours, 15-mile round trip, \$20 supplies
Floor \$442.37

Quote \$525

\$82.63 profit inside it

One person per job, driving at 30 mph, vehicle at 76 cents a mile. These are worked examples from the numbers above, not market prices for your area.

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Where the numbers come from

Self-employment tax: 15.3% on 92.35% of net earnings (IRS Topic 554 and Schedule SE). Vehicle: IRS business standard mileage rate of 76 cents a mile for July 1 to December 31, 2026 (IRS news release IR-2026-29). Checked October 7, 2026. Income tax is your own estimate; your real rate depends on your whole return. The example uses made-up inputs.

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